# HIDDEN COORDINATES AND SELECTION RULES IN THE FOURIER ENTROPY-INFLUENCE CONJECTURE

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Abstract. For a Boolean function $f$ and a coordinate $i$, the erasure entropy $E_i(f)$ is the conditional entropy of the event $i \in U$ given $U \setminus \{i\}$, where $U$ is drawn from the spectral distribution $\hat{f}^2$. The Fourier entropy-influence conjecture is equivalent to every non-constant $f$ having a coordinate with $E_i(f) \le c\,\mathrm{Inf}_i(f)$ for an absolute $c$. We study a family of monotone functions with a hidden coordinate: a variable that enters only through one point below a majority threshold. Its ratio $E_i/\mathrm{Inf}_i$ tends to infinity, yet the sum of the erasure entropies over all coordinates is at most twice the total influence, and at most five times the total influence after every other variable is replaced by a self-dual monotone function on fresh variables. These functions show that no rule that picks the coordinate of smallest influence, of largest influence, of largest or of smallest normalised level-two Fourier weight, or the variable lying in the most shortest minterms, can serve in the equivalence, even for monotone functions. We also show that the two singleton identities of monotone functions do not by themselves bound the erasure entropy, and we give the exact maxima of $\min_i E_i/\mathrm{Inf}_i$, $H/I$ and $\sum_i E_i/I$ over all monotone functions of at most seven variables.

## 1. Introduction

For $f\colon \{0,1\}^n \to \{-1,1\}$ write $f = \sum_S \hat{f}(S)\chi_S$ with $\chi_S(x) = (-1)^{\sum_{j\in S} x_j}$, and let $U$ be a random subset with $\Pr[U = S] = \mu(S) = \hat{f}(S)^2$. The Fourier entropy is $H(f) = H(U)$ and the total influence is $I(f) = \mathbb{E}|U| = \sum_i \mathrm{Inf}_i(f)$, where $\mathrm{Inf}_i(f) = \Pr[i \in U]$. The Fourier entropy-influence (FEI) conjecture of Friedgut and Kalai [4] asks for an absolute $C$ with $H(f) \le C\,I(f)$ for every Boolean $f$. It is known for symmetric functions [14], for read-once formulas [13, 3] and for read-$k$ decision trees with $k$ fixed [22]; its min-entropy version is known for read-$k$ DNFs with $k$ fixed [15, 1]; Han [6] bounds $H(f)$ by a multiple of $I(f)$ plus $\sum_i \mathrm{Inf}_i(f)\log_2(1/\mathrm{Inf}_i(f))$, and Hod [7] shows, with monotone functions, that the best constant exceeds 6.45, and explicit balanced monotone functions on 14 to 18 variables raise this to 6.5218 [9, 10, 11].

The erasure entropy of $f$ at $i$ is

$$E_i(f) = H\big(\mathbf{1}[i \in U] \;\big|\; U \setminus \{i\}\big),$$

the conditional entropy of one coordinate given the others in the sense of Verdú and Weissman [21]. It is the part of the entropy drop from $f$ to its two restrictions at $x_i$ that is not controlled by a constant times $\mathrm{Inf}_i$ [6, Remarks 3.1–3.2], [5, (32)], and the FEI conjecture holds if and only if

$$G = \sup_f \min_{i\colon \mathrm{Inf}_i(f)>0} \frac{E_i(f)}{\mathrm{Inf}_i(f)}$$

is finite [16]. One direction is immediate from $\sum_i E_i \le H$. The other restricts $f$ one coordinate at a time, each time at a coordinate with small ratio, and does not say which coordinate that is. This paper is about that choice.

Section 3 studies the functions

$$f_k(y,x) = \mathrm{MAJ}_k(y) \vee \big(x \wedge [y \ge y^0]\big), \qquad k \text{ odd},$$

where $y^0 \in \{0,1\}^k$ has $(k-1)/2$ ones and $[y \geq y^0]$ is the AND of the coordinates of $y$ at which $y^0$ is 1. The variable $x$ changes the value only at the single point $y = y^0$, so $\mathrm{Inf}_x(f_k) = 2^{-k}$, and the ratio $E_x/\mathrm{Inf}_x$ tends to infinity (Proposition 5). Nevertheless the erasure entropies of all coordinates together are small:

**Theorem 1.** *For every odd $k$, $\sum_i E_i(f_k) \leq 2\, I(f_k)$. If every $y_j$ is replaced by a non-constant self-dual monotone function $\varphi_j$ of its own block of fresh variables, the resulting monotone function $F$ satisfies $E_x(F) = E_x(f_k)$, $E_\ell(F) < 4\,\mathrm{Inf}_\ell(F)$ at every relevant variable $\ell \neq x$, and $\sum_i E_i(F) \leq 5\, I(F)$.*

The large ratio at $x$ is paid for by the total influence: $E_x \leq h_2(2^{-k})$, which is far below $I(f_k) \geq 1$. Two facts drive the proof. The parity of $|U|$ determines whether $i \in U$ once $U \setminus \{i\}$ is known, so every $E_i$ is at most the binary entropy of the Fourier weight on even levels, and for $f_k$ that weight is exactly $2^{-k}$ (Lemma 3). After the substitution, $E_\ell$ has an exact expression in terms of the spectrum of $f_k$ (Proposition 6). Theorem 1 does not by itself give $H \leq C\, I$ for these functions, since the passage from erasure entropies to $H$ uses a good coordinate in every restriction and the family is not closed under restrictions; its point is that an unbounded ratio at one coordinate is compatible with a bounded sum.

Section 5 uses these functions against simple selection rules.

**Theorem 2.** *For each of the following rules there are monotone functions on which the coordinate it selects has $E_i/\mathrm{Inf}_i$ as large as we like, with ties broken in any way: the coordinate of smallest influence; of largest influence; of largest normalised level-two weight $W_i^{(2)}/\mathrm{Inf}_i$; of smallest normalised level-two weight; the variable lying in the most minterms of smallest size; the variable of smallest $E_i/\mathrm{Inf}_i$ among those lying both in a minterm of smallest size and in a maxterm of smallest size.*

Here $W_i^{(2)}(f) = \sum_{j \neq i} \hat{f}(\{i,j\})^2$. That the largest influence fails was shown in [17] by a different construction. For the rule of smallest normalised level-two weight, $f_k$ itself is not a counterexample; there the hidden coordinate is made pivotal at two complementary points of the middle layer, which removes its level-two weight altogether (Proposition 9).

Section 6 shows that the identities $\hat{f}(\{i\})^2 = \mathrm{Inf}_i(f)^2$ and $\sum_i \mathrm{Inf}_i(f)^2 \leq 1$, which hold for monotone $f$, are not enough to bound the erasure entropy: an exchangeable probability law on subsets of $[n]$ satisfies both and has $E_i/\Pr[i \in U] \geq \log_2(n)/288$. Section 7 gives the exact maxima of the three ratios $\min_i E_i/\mathrm{Inf}_i$, $H/I$ and $\sum_i E_i/I$ over all monotone functions on at most seven variables, and the worst cases of the simple rules on at most six.

The last rule of Theorem 2 needs more than the hidden coordinate of $f_k$, which lies in no shortest maxterm. The rule is bounded by 2.6974 when a shortest minterm or maxterm is a single variable (Proposition 10), and on at most six variables its worst case equals $G_{\mathrm{mon}}(n)$. It fails because a variant of $f_k$ has its hidden coordinate in both a shortest minterm and a shortest maxterm (Proposition 11), and substituting threshold functions of slightly different minterm and maxterm sizes leaves that coordinate the only variable in both, with almost the same ratio (Proposition 12).

## 2. Preliminaries

All logarithms are to base 2, $\eta = \log_2 e$, and $h_2$ is the binary entropy. For $p, q \geq 0$ put

$$\Phi(p,q) = (p+q)\, h_2\Big(\frac{q}{p+q}\Big) = p \log \frac{p+q}{p} + q \log \frac{p+q}{q}, \qquad \Phi(p,0) = \Phi(0,q) = 0.$$

Then

$$E_i(f) = \sum_{T \not\ni i} \Phi\big(\mu(T), \mu(T \cup \{i\})\big), \qquad \mathrm{Inf}_i(f) = \sum_{T \not\ni i} \mu(T \cup \{i\}). \tag{1}$$

$\Phi$ is concave and positively homogeneous of degree one, hence superadditive: $\sum_t \Phi(p_t, q_t) \le \Phi(\sum_t p_t, \sum_t q_t)$. It is nondecreasing in each argument, and $\Phi(p, q) \ge q \log(p/q)$ when $p \ge q$, since both of its terms are nonnegative and $(p+q)/q \ge p/q$. We use $h_2(t) \le t \log(e/t)$, which follows from $-(1-t)\ln(1-t) \le t$.

For monotone $f$ (with $f = 1 - 2F$ for a monotone $F$, or $2F - 1$; squared coefficients do not depend on the choice), $|\hat{f}(\{i\})| = \mathrm{Inf}_i(f)$. A Boolean function is self-dual if $f(\bar{x}) = -f(x)$, where $\bar{x}$ is the complement of $x$; then $\hat{f}(S) = 0$ for every $S$ of even size, and in particular $\hat{f}(\emptyset) = 0$.

**Lemma 3.** *Let $\varepsilon = \Pr[\,|U| \text{ even}]$. Then $E_i(f) \le h_2(\varepsilon)$ for every $i$, and $E_i(f) \le h_2(\mathrm{Inf}_i(f))$.*

*Proof.* Given $U \setminus \{i\}$, the parity of $|U|$ and the indicator of $i \in U$ determine each other, so $E_i = H(|U| \bmod 2 \mid U \setminus \{i\}) \le H(|U| \bmod 2) = h_2(\varepsilon)$. The second bound drops the conditioning. □

## 3. The hidden coordinate

Fix an odd $k$, let $y^0 \in \{0,1\}^k$ have $(k-1)/2$ ones, and let $f_k$ be as in the introduction, written in $\pm 1$ values with $+1$ for true. Put

$$\delta = 2^{-k}, \qquad a = \binom{k-1}{(k-1)/2} 2^{1-k},$$

so that $a$ is the influence of every variable of $\mathrm{MAJ}_k$. For $k = 1$ the vector $y^0$ is empty and $f_1 = y \vee x$.

**Lemma 4.** (1) *$f_k = \mathrm{MAJ}_k + (1+x)\mathbf{1}[y = y^0]$, where $x$ is the $\pm 1$ value of the hidden variable.*
(2) *$\mathrm{Inf}_x(f_k) = \delta$; $\mathrm{Inf}_{y_j}(f_k) = a + \delta$ if $y^0_j = 1$ and $a - \delta$ if $y^0_j = 0$; $I(f_k) = ka \ge 1$.*
(3) *The Fourier weight of $f_k$ on sets of even size is exactly $\delta$.*

*Proof.* If $y \ge y^0$ and $y \ne y^0$ then $|y| \ge (k+1)/2$, so the clause $x \wedge [y \ge y^0]$ changes the value only at $y = y^0$, where $\mathrm{MAJ}_k = -1$ and $f_k = x$; this is (1). The derivative in $x$ is $\mathbf{1}[y = y^0]$, so $\mathrm{Inf}_x = \Pr[y = y^0] = \delta$. Setting $f_k(1, y^0) = 1$ creates a pivotal edge in direction $j$ when $y^0_j = 1$, since $\mathrm{MAJ}_k(y^0 - e_j) = -1$, and removes one when $y^0_j = 0$, since $\mathrm{MAJ}_k(y^0 + e_j) = 1$; each edge carries influence $\delta$. There are $(k-1)/2$ coordinates of the first kind and $(k+1)/2$ of the second, so $I(f_k) = \delta + ka - \delta = ka$. As $a$ is the largest atom of the binomial law on $\{0, \dots, k-1\}$, $a \ge 1/k$. For (3): $\mathrm{MAJ}_k$ is self-dual, so its spectrum lies on odd sets not containing $x$. The coefficients of $(1+x)\mathbf{1}[y = y^0]$ all have modulus $\delta$, one at each $T$ and one at each $T \cup \{x\}$, $T \subseteq [k]$; the $2^k$ sets of even size among them carry no weight of $\mathrm{MAJ}_k$ and have total weight $2^k \delta^2 = \delta$. □

*Proof of Theorem 1 for $f_k$.* By Lemmas 3 and 4, $\sum_i E_i(f_k) \le (k+1) h_2(\delta)$, and $I(f_k) \ge 1$. For $k = 1$, $f_1 = y \vee x$ has $\mu$ uniform on four sets, so $E_x = E_y = 1$ and $\sum_i E_i = 2 = 2I$. For $k = 3$, $I = 3/2$ and $4h_2(1/8) < 2.18 < 3$. For odd $k \ge 5$, $(k+1)h_2(\delta) \le (k+1)(k+\eta)2^{-k}$, which is $< 1.21$ at $k = 5$ and decreases, since its ratio from $k$ to $k+2$ is $\frac{1}{4}\frac{k+3}{k+1}\frac{k+2+\eta}{k+\eta} < 1$. □

**Proposition 5.** *For odd $k$ large enough,*

$$\frac{E_x(f_k)}{\mathrm{Inf}_x(f_k)} \;\ge\; \Big(\frac{1}{2} - \frac{4k}{(k-3)^2}\Big)\Big(\frac{k-1}{4} - 2\log k\Big).$$

*Proof.* Write $g = \mathrm{MAJ}_k + \mathbf{1}[y = y^0]$ for the average of $f_k$ over $x$. By (1), $E_x = \sum_T \Phi(\hat{g}(T)^2, \delta^2)$ over $T \subseteq [k]$, and $\mathrm{Inf}_x = 2^k\delta^2$, so $E_x/\mathrm{Inf}_x$ is the average of $\delta^{-2}\Phi(\hat{g}(T)^2, \delta^2)$ over uniform $T$. For $|T| = r$ odd, $\widehat{\mathrm{MAJ}_k}(T)$ has modulus

$$b_r = a\binom{(k-1)/2}{(r-1)/2}\Big/\binom{k-1}{r-1}.$$

Indeed, for $j \in T$ it equals the coefficient at $T \setminus \{j\}$ of the derivative in $y_j$, the indicator of the middle layer of the other $2m = k-1$ coordinates, and $\sum_S \mathbb{E}[\chi_S \mid |z| = m]\, t^{|S|} = (1-t)^m(1+t)^m = (1-t^2)^m$ gives $\mathbb{E}[\chi_S \mid |z| = m] = (-1)^s\binom{m}{s}/\binom{2m}{2s}$ for $|S| = 2s$. If $(k-1)/4 \le r-1 \le 3(k-1)/4$ then $\binom{m}{(r-1)/2} \ge 2^{(k-1)/8}$, and with $a \ge 1/k$ and $\binom{k-1}{r-1} \le 2^{k-1}$ we get $b_r/\delta \ge 2^{(k-1)/8+1}/k \ge 2$ for large $k$. Then $|\hat{g}(T)| \ge b_r - \delta \ge b_r/2$ and $\delta^{-2}\Phi(\hat{g}(T)^2, \delta^2) \ge \log(\hat{g}(T)^2/\delta^2) \ge (k-1)/4 - 2\log k$. The set of such $T$ has probability at least $\frac{1}{2} - \Pr[\,||T| - k/2| > (k-3)/4\,] \ge \frac{1}{2} - \frac{4k}{(k-3)^2}$ by Chebyshev's inequality. □

The ratio is 3.52, 5.78 and 9.27 at $k = 3, 9, 17$.

## 4. Substitution

Let $\varphi_1, \dots, \varphi_k$ be non-constant self-dual monotone functions on disjoint blocks of fresh variables, and $F(z, x) = f_k(\varphi_1(z^1), \dots, \varphi_k(z^k), x)$. Write $\mu$ for the spectral distribution of $f_k$ and $\delta_j$ for $\mathrm{Inf}_{y_j}(f_k)$. For a variable $\ell$ of block $j$ let $\tau = \mathrm{Inf}_\ell(\varphi_j) = |\hat{\varphi}_j(\{\ell\})|$.

**Proposition 6.** *With $p_T = \mu(T)$ and $q_T = \mu(T \cup \{y_j\})$ for $T$ a subset of the coordinates of $f_k$ other than $y_j$,*

$$\mathrm{Inf}_\ell(F) = \tau\delta_j, \qquad E_\ell(F) = \sum_T \Phi(p_T, \tau^2 q_T).$$

*Moreover $E_x(F) = E_x(f_k)$, $\mathrm{Inf}_x(F) = \delta$, and the weight of $F$ on sets of even size is $\delta$.*

*Proof.* Since $\hat{\varphi}_j(\emptyset) = 0$, expanding $f_k = \sum_T \hat{f}_k(T)\prod_{j\in T} y_j$ and substituting gives $\hat{F}(S) = \hat{f}_k(T)\prod_{j\in T}\hat{\varphi}_j(S_j)$, where $S_j = S \cap \mathrm{block}_j$ and $T$ consists of $x$ if $x \in S$ and the $j$ with $S_j \neq \emptyset$. Fix the parts of a set $V \not\ni \ell$ outside block $j$. If $V_j \neq \emptyset$, the sets $V$ and $V \cup \{\ell\}$ have the same $T$, and their block-$j$ parts differ in size by one; as $\varphi_j$ is self-dual, one of the two coefficients vanishes and the pair contributes $\Phi(\cdot, 0) = 0$. If $V_j = \emptyset$, the pair is $(T, T \cup \{y_j\})$ with factors 1 and $\tau^2$, times a common factor $\prod_{i\in T}\hat{\varphi}_i(S_i)^2$. By homogeneity of $\Phi$ and $\sum_{S_i\neq\emptyset}\hat{\varphi}_i(S_i)^2 = 1$ (Parseval and $\hat{\varphi}_i(\emptyset) = 0$), summing over the other blocks leaves $\Phi(p_T, \tau^2 q_T)$. The influence follows in the same way from $\sum_{S\ni\ell}\hat{\varphi}_j(S)^2 = \tau$. For $x$, the pairs $(V, V \cup \{x\})$ correspond to $(T, T \cup \{x\})$ with a common factor, so $E_x$ and $\mathrm{Inf}_x$ are unchanged. Each nonempty $S_i$ has odd size, so $|S| \equiv |T| \pmod 2$ and the even weight is that of $f_k$. □

**Corollary 7.** $E_\ell(F) \le \min\big(h_2(\delta), h_2(\tau^2\delta_j)\big)$.

*Proof.* The first bound is Lemma 3 with Proposition 6. For the second, superadditivity gives $E_\ell(F) \le \Phi(\sum_T p_T, \tau^2\sum_T q_T) = \Phi(1-\delta_j, \tau^2\delta_j) \le \Phi(1-\tau^2\delta_j, \tau^2\delta_j)$, using that $\Phi$ is nondecreasing in its first argument. □

*Proof of Theorem 1 for $F$.* Let $k \ge 3$. Then $\delta \le 1/(2k)$, so $\delta_j \ge a - \delta \ge 1/(2k)$. Put $r = \sqrt{\delta/\delta_j}$. If $\tau \ge r$, Corollary 7 and $h_2(t) \le t\log(e/t)$ give

$$\frac{E_\ell}{\mathrm{Inf}_\ell} \le \frac{h_2(\delta)}{r\delta_j} \le r\log\frac{e}{\delta}.$$

If $\tau \le r$, they give $E_\ell/\mathrm{Inf}_\ell \le \tau \log(e/(\tau^2\delta_j))$, whose derivative in $\tau$ is $\log(1/(\tau^2\delta_j)) - \eta > 0$, because $\tau^2\delta_j \le \delta \le 1/8 < 1/e$; so it is at most its value $r\log(e/\delta)$ at $\tau = r$. Hence

$$\frac{E_\ell(F)}{\mathrm{Inf}_\ell(F)} \le \sqrt{\delta/\delta_j}\,\log(e/\delta) \le B_k := \sqrt{2k2^{-k}}\,(k+\eta).$$

Here $B_3 < \frac{9}{4}\sqrt{3} < 4$, and $B_{k+2}/B_k = \frac{1}{2}\sqrt{1+2/k}\,(1+2/(k+\eta)) \le \frac{1}{2}\sqrt{5/3}\cdot\frac{3}{2} < 1$. For $k=1$, $\delta = \delta_1 = 1/2$ and $E_\ell/\mathrm{Inf}_\ell \le h_2(\tau^2/2)/(\tau/2) \le \tau\log(2e/\tau^2) \le 2\sqrt{2/e}\,\eta < 3$.

For the sum, $I(F) = \delta + \sum_j \delta_j I(\varphi_j)$, and $I(\varphi_j) \ge \mathrm{Var}(\varphi_j) = 1$, so $I(F) \ge \delta + \sum_j \delta_j = I(f_k) \ge 1$. Therefore

$$\sum_i E_i(F) = E_x(F) + \sum_\ell E_\ell(F) \le h_2(\delta) + 4\sum_j \delta_j I(\varphi_j) \le I(F) + 4I(F). \qquad \square$$

*Remark* 8. The bound $E_\ell < 4\mathrm{Inf}_\ell$ holds at every variable of every block, whatever the sizes of the blocks; in particular for majority blocks of any size and for iterated majorities. Since $x$ keeps the same $E_x$ and $\mathrm{Inf}_x$, the ratio at $x$ still tends to infinity with $k$.

## 5. Selection rules

*Proof of Theorem 2. Smallest influence.* In $f_k$, $\mathrm{Inf}_x = \delta < a - \delta \le \mathrm{Inf}_{y_j}$ for $k \ge 3$, so the rule picks $x$, and Proposition 5 applies.

*Largest normalised level-two weight.* $\mathrm{MAJ}_k$ has no weight on sets of size two, so every coefficient of $f_k$ at a set of size two is a coefficient of $(1+x)\mathbf{1}[y = y^0]$, of modulus $\delta$. Thus $W_i^{(2)} = k\delta^2$ for every coordinate, and maximising $W_i^{(2)}/\mathrm{Inf}_i$ is minimising $\mathrm{Inf}_i$.

*Largest influence.* Substitute $\varphi_j = \mathrm{MAJ}_{2s+1}$ for every $j$. Then $\tau = \binom{2s}{s}4^{-s} \le (s+1)^{-1/2}$ (the ratio from $s$ to $s+1$ is $\frac{2s+1}{2s+2}$, and $(\frac{2s+1}{2s+2})^2 \le \frac{s+1}{s+2}$). For $s+1 > 4^k$ every variable of a block has influence $\tau\delta_j < \delta$, so $x$ is the unique coordinate of largest influence, and by Proposition 6 its ratio is that of $f_k$.

*Most shortest minterms.* Substitute $\varphi_j = \mathrm{MAJ}_3$. The minterms of $F$ are $x$ together with a minterm of $\mathrm{MAJ}_3$ in each block $j$ with $y_j^0 = 1$, of size $1 + 2\cdot\frac{k-1}{2} = k$, and minterms of $\mathrm{MAJ}_3$ in $(k+1)/2$ of the blocks, of size $k+1$. So every shortest minterm contains $x$, while a variable of a block lies in two of the three minterms of $\mathrm{MAJ}_3$ and hence in fewer of them. The rule picks $x$.

*Smallest normalised level-two weight.* This is Proposition 9 below.

*Smallest ratio among the variables in a shortest minterm and a shortest maxterm.* This is Proposition 12 below. $\square$

For $f_k$ the hidden coordinate has the same level-two weight as every other coordinate, which is not the smallest normalised value. The next construction removes it.

Let $k \ge 6$ be even, let $y^0 \in \{0,1\}^k$ have $k/2$ ones and $y^1 = \bar{y}^0$. Let $B(y) = 1$ if $|y| \ge k/2$ and 0 otherwise, and define $f'_k(y,x) = B(y)$ except that $f'_k(y,x) = x$ when $y \in \{y^0, y^1\}$. Lowering a point of the middle layer from 1 to 0 preserves monotonicity, so $f'_k$ is monotone.

**Proposition 9.** *$W_x^{(2)}(f'_k) = 0$ and $W_{y_j}^{(2)}(f'_k) > 0$ for every $j$, so $x$ is the unique coordinate of smallest normalised level-two weight;* $\mathrm{Inf}_x = 2^{1-k}$, $\mathrm{Inf}_{y_j} = \binom{k}{k/2}2^{-k}$ *for every $j$; and for even $k$ large enough*

$$\frac{E_x(f'_k)}{\mathrm{Inf}_x(f'_k)} \;\ge\; \Big(1 - \frac{8}{k}\Big)\Big(\frac{k}{4} - 4 - 2\log(k+1)\Big).$$

*Proof.* With $P = \mathbf{1}[y \in \{y^0, y^1\}]$ we have $f'_k = B - (1-x)P$ in $\pm 1$ values, the derivative in $x$ is $P$, and the average over $x$ is $g = B - P$. Put $\delta = 2^{1-k}$. Since $\chi_T(y^1) = (-1)^{|T|}\chi_T(y^0)$, $\hat{P}(T)$ vanishes for odd $|T|$ and has modulus $\delta$ for even $|T|$. So $\mathrm{Inf}_x = \Pr[y \in \{y^0, y^1\}] = \delta$ and the

coefficient of $f'_k$ at $\{x, y_j\}$, which is $\hat{P}(\{y_j\})$, is zero: $W^{(2)}_x = 0$. At $y^0$ and at $y^1$ the change creates or removes a pivotal edge in direction $j$ according to the $j$th bit, and the two bits are opposite, so $\mathrm{Inf}_{y_j}(f'_k) = \mathrm{Inf}_j(B) = \binom{k}{k/2}2^{-k} =: a_0$.

In $\pm1$ values, $B$ is the sum of an odd function, the sign of $|y| - k/2$ with 0 on the middle layer, and the indicator of the middle layer. Only the latter has even coefficients, and by the generating function of Proposition 5, for even $r = |T|$,

$$|\hat{B}(T)| = a_0 \binom{k/2}{r/2} \Big/ \binom{k}{r}. \tag{2}$$

At $r = 2$ this is $a_0/(k-1)$, and $a_0/((k-1)\delta) = \binom{k}{k/2}/(2(k-1))$ equals 2 at $k = 6$ and increases. So $|\hat{f}'_k(\{y_j, y_l\})| \geq |\hat{B}(\{y_j, y_l\})| - \delta > 0$ and $W^{(2)}_{y_j} > 0$.

The derivative spectrum is uniform over the even subsets $T$ of $[k]$, and $E_x/\mathrm{Inf}_x$ is the average of $\delta^{-2}\Phi(\hat{g}(T)^2, \delta^2)$. For even $r \in [k/4, 3k/4]$, (2) with $\binom{k/2}{r/2} \geq 2^{k/8}$, $a_0 \geq 1/(k+1)$ and $\binom{k}{r} \leq 2^k$ gives $|\hat{B}(T)| \geq 2^{-7k/8}/(k+1) \geq 2\delta$ for large $k$, hence $|\hat{g}(T)| \geq |\hat{B}(T)|/2$ and $\delta^{-2}\Phi(\hat{g}(T)^2, \delta^2) \geq k/4 - 4 - 2\log(k+1)$. By Chebyshev's inequality, conditioned on $|T|$ even, $|T| \in [k/4, 3k/4]$ with probability at least $1 - 8/k$. □

At $k = 18$ the ratio at $x$ is 14.28, while the smallest ratio over all coordinates is 1.60.

**Shortest minterms and shortest maxterms.** In each of these functions the hidden coordinate does not lie both in a shortest minterm and in a shortest maxterm: in $f_k$ and its substitutions it lies in no shortest maxterm, and in $f'_k$ in no shortest minterm. For monotone $f$ let $A(f)$ be the set of variables lying in some shortest minterm and $B(f)$ the set lying in some shortest maxterm. Every minterm meets every maxterm, so $A(f) \cap B(f)$ is not empty. Consider the rule that chooses a variable of $A(f) \cap B(f)$ minimising $E_i/\mathrm{Inf}_i$. It is bounded when a shortest minterm or a shortest maxterm is a single variable, but not in general.

**Proposition 10.** *Let $f = x \wedge g$, where $g$ is a monotone function of the other variables that is not identically false, and let $p = \Pr[g \text{ true}]$. Then $\mathrm{Inf}_x(f) = p$ and*

$$\frac{E_x(f)}{\mathrm{Inf}_x(f)} = 2(1-p) + \frac{\Phi\big((1-p)^2, p^2\big)}{p} \;\leq\; 4(1-p).$$

*The middle expression tends to 2 as $p \to 0$, equals 2 at $p = 1/2$, and its maximum over $p \in (0, 1]$ is 2.697377, attained near $p = 0.1994$.*

*Proof.* Write $x$ and $g$ in $\pm1$ values with $-1$ for true. Then $f = \frac{1+g}{2} + x\,\frac{1-g}{2}$, so for $T$ not containing $x$, $\hat{f}(T) = \frac{1}{2}(\mathbf{1}[T = \emptyset] + \hat{g}(T))$ and $\hat{f}(T \cup \{x\}) = \frac{1}{2}(\mathbf{1}[T = \emptyset] - \hat{g}(T))$. As $\hat{g}(\emptyset) = 1 - 2p$, we get $\mu(\emptyset) = (1-p)^2$, $\mu(\{x\}) = p^2$, and $\mu(T) = \mu(T \cup \{x\}) = \hat{g}(T)^2/4$ for $T \neq \emptyset$. Since $\Phi(c, c) = 2c$, (1) gives

$$E_x = \Phi\big((1-p)^2, p^2\big) + \tfrac{1}{2}\big(1 - (1-2p)^2\big), \qquad \mathrm{Inf}_x = p^2 + \tfrac{1}{4}\big(1 - (1-2p)^2\big) = p,$$

and the second term of $E_x$ is $2p(1-p)$. For the bound, $\Phi(a, b) = (a+b)h_2(b/(a+b)) \leq 2\sqrt{ab}$ by the inequality $h_2(t) \leq 2\sqrt{t(1-t)}$, which follows from $h_2(t) \leq (4t(1-t))^{1/\ln 4}$ [20]; here $2\sqrt{ab} = 2p(1-p)$. □

If a shortest maxterm of a monotone $f$ is a single variable $x$, then $f = x \wedge g$ with $g$ the restriction $x = 1$, and every shortest maxterm is a single variable of this kind. So every variable of $B(f)$, and hence of $A(f) \cap B(f)$, has $E_i/\mathrm{Inf}_i < 2.6974$. The dual $f^\dagger(z) = \neg f(\bar{z})$ exchanges minterms and maxterms and has the same squared Fourier coefficients, so the same holds when a shortest minterm is a single variable. In these cases any variable of $A \cap B$ will do.

In general a variable of $A \cap B$ can be bad. For odd $k \geq 3$ let $m = (k-1)/2$, let $y^0$ have ones exactly at $y_1, \dots, y_m$, put $y^1 = y^0 + e_{m+1}$, let $M$ be $\mathrm{MAJ}_k$ with its value at $y^1$ changed to false, and

$$\tilde{f}_k(y, x) = M(y) \vee \big(x \wedge [y \geq y^0]\big).$$

The point $y^1$ lies in the lowest true layer of $\mathrm{MAJ}_k$, so $M$ and $\tilde{f}_k$ are monotone.

**Proposition 11.** *The variable $x$ lies in a shortest minterm and in a shortest maxterm of $\tilde{f}_k$, $\mathrm{Inf}_x(\tilde{f}_k) = 2^{1-k}$, and for odd $k$ large enough*

$$\frac{E_x(\tilde{f}_k)}{\mathrm{Inf}_x(\tilde{f}_k)} \;\geq\; \Big(\frac{1}{2} - \frac{4(k-1)}{(k-5)^2}\Big)\Big(\frac{k-1}{4} - 2\log k\Big).$$

*Proof.* A true point has weight at least $m+1$: with $x$ false it needs $M(y)$, so $|y| \geq m+1$, and with $x$ true it needs $y \geq y^0$ or $M(y)$. Hence $\{x, y_1, \dots, y_m\}$ is a shortest minterm. Every point of weight $m+2$ is true: with $x$ false, $|y| = m+2$ and $M(y)$ holds; with $x$ true, $|y| = m+1$ and either $y = y^1 \geq y^0$ or $M(y)$ holds. The point with $x$ false and $y = y^1$ is false and has weight $m+1$, so the variables at which it is 0, among them $x$, form a shortest maxterm.

In $\pm 1$ values with $+1$ for true, $\tilde{f}_k = \mathrm{MAJ}_k + (1+x)\mathbf{1}[y = y^0] - (1-x)\mathbf{1}[y = y^1]$. The derivative in $x$ is $D = \mathbf{1}[y = y^0] + \mathbf{1}[y = y^1]$ and the average over $x$ is $\bar{g} = \mathrm{MAJ}_k + \mathbf{1}[y = y^0] - \mathbf{1}[y = y^1]$. With $\delta = 2^{-k}$, $\hat{D}(T) = \delta(\chi_T(y^0) + \chi_T(y^1))$ vanishes if $y_{m+1} \in T$ and has modulus $2\delta$ otherwise. So $\mathrm{Inf}_x = 2^{k-1}(2\delta)^2 = 2^{1-k}$, and $E_x/\mathrm{Inf}_x$ is the average of $(2\delta)^{-2}\Phi(\hat{\bar{g}}(T)^2, 4\delta^2)$ over the $2^{k-1}$ sets $T \subseteq [k] \setminus \{m+1\}$. For these $T$, $\chi_T(y^0) = \chi_T(y^1)$, the two indicators cancel, and $|\hat{\bar{g}}(T)| = b_r$ for $|T| = r$ odd, with $b_r$ as in the proof of Proposition 5. If $(k-1)/4 \leq r-1 \leq 3(k-1)/4$, that proof gives $b_r/(2\delta) \geq 2^{(k-1)/8}/k \geq 1$ for large $k$, hence $(2\delta)^{-2}\Phi(b_r^2, 4\delta^2) \geq \log(b_r^2/(4\delta^2)) \geq (k-1)/4 - 2\log k$. Now $|T|$ is binomial with parameters $k-1$ and $\frac{1}{2}$; it is odd with probability $\frac{1}{2}$, and by Chebyshev's inequality $\big||T| - \frac{k-1}{2}\big| > \frac{k-5}{4}$ with probability at most $4(k-1)/(k-5)^2$. Otherwise $(k+3)/4 \leq |T| \leq (3k-7)/4$, which is the required range. □

Both factors of the bound in Proposition 11, and of those in Propositions 5 and 9, are positive only from $k = 45$, $k = 45$ and $k = 66$ respectively. For smaller $k$ the displayed product says nothing: at $k = 5$ the right side of Proposition 5 is 16.4, a product of two negative factors.

At $k = 3, 5, \dots, 13$ the ratio at $x$ is 1.80, 2.56, 3.17, 3.90, 4.70 and 5.55, while the smallest ratio over $A(\tilde{f}_k) \cap B(\tilde{f}_k)$ is the smallest over all coordinates, 1.00 at $k = 3$ and 0.0060 at $k = 13$. So $\tilde{f}_k$ does not defeat the rule. A substitution removes the other variables from $A \cap B$.

For $t \geq 1$ let $T_t$ be the function of $2t$ variables that is true when at least $t$ of them are true, and $T_t'$ the one that is true when at least $t+1$ are. Their shortest minterms have sizes $t$ and $t+1$, and their shortest maxterms sizes $t+1$ and $t$. Let $F_{k,t}$ be obtained from $\tilde{f}_k$ by replacing $y_j$ with $T_t$ of a block of fresh variables for $j \leq m$ and with $T_t'$ of a block of fresh variables for $j > m$.

**Proposition 12.** *$A(F_{k,t}) \cap B(F_{k,t}) = \{x\}$, and for each $k$,*

$$\frac{E_x(F_{k,t})}{\mathrm{Inf}_x(F_{k,t})} \to \frac{E_x(\tilde{f}_k)}{\mathrm{Inf}_x(\tilde{f}_k)} \qquad (t \to \infty).$$

*Hence the rule that chooses the variable of smallest $E_i/\mathrm{Inf}_i$ in $A \cap B$ has unbounded ratio on monotone functions.*

*Proof.* If each $y_j$ of a monotone $g$ is replaced by a non-constant monotone $\varphi_j$ of its own block, the minterms of the result are the sets $\bigcup_{j \in S} R_j$, together with $x$ when $x \in S$, where $S$ is a minterm of $g$ and each $R_j$ is a minterm of $\varphi_j$; the same holds for maxterms. So a shortest

minterm of the result comes from a minterm $S$ of $g$ minimising $\sum_{j\in S} a_j$, where $a_x = 1$ and $a_j$ is the size of a shortest minterm of $\varphi_j$, and likewise for maxterms.

Write $S_0 = \{y_1, \dots, y_m\}$ and $R = \{y_{m+2}, \dots, y_k\}$. The minterms of $\tilde{f}_k$ are $\{x\} \cup S_0$ and the sets of $m+1$ variables $y_j$ other than $S_0 \cup \{y_{m+1}\}$: a true point either has $y \geq y^0$ and $x$ true or satisfies $M$, and $M$ is true exactly at the points of weight at least $m+1$ other than $y^1$. The first has $\sum a_j = 1 + mt$. Any other contains $i \leq m$ variables of $S_0$ and $m+1-i \geq 1$ others, and has $\sum a_j = (m+1)t + (m+1-i) > 1 + mt$. The maximal false points of $\tilde{f}_k$ are the point with $x$ false and $y = y^1$, and the points with $x$ true and $|y| = m$, $y \neq y^0$; the maxterms are therefore $\{x\} \cup R$ and the sets of $m+1$ variables $y_j$ other than $R \cup \{y_{m+1}\}$. The first has $\sum b_j = 1 + mt$, and every other contains a variable of $S_0$ and has $\sum b_j \geq (m+1)t + 1$. Hence every shortest minterm of $F_{k,t}$ consists of $x$ and variables of the blocks of $S_0$, every shortest maxterm consists of $x$ and variables of the blocks of $R$, and $A \cap B = \{x\}$.

For the ratio let $\mu_j$ be the probability that $\varphi_j$ is true, $\sigma_j^2 = \mu_j(1-\mu_j)$, and expand $\tilde{f}_k$, in $\pm 1$ values, in the orthonormal basis $\prod_{j\in S}(y_j - \mu_j)/\sigma_j$ (times $x$ when $x \in S$) of the product measure with $\Pr[y_j = 1] = \mu_j$ and $x$ uniform (the biased setting of [8]); call the coefficients $c_\mu(S)$. Each $\psi_j = (\varphi_j - \mu_j)/\sigma_j$ has mean 0 and variance 1 under the uniform measure on its block, so $\sum_{R_j \neq \emptyset} \hat{\psi}_j(R_j)^2 = 1$, and the coefficient of $F_{k,t}$ at the union of $S \cap \{x\}$ and sets $R_j \neq \emptyset$, $j \in S \setminus \{x\}$, is $c_\mu(S) \prod_j \hat{\psi}_j(R_j)$. So the spectral sample of $F_{k,t}$ is obtained by drawing $S$ with probability $c_\mu(S)^2$ and then each $R_j$ independently. It contains $x$ exactly when $S$ does, it determines $S \setminus \{x\}$, and given $S \setminus \{x\}$ the $R_j$ do not depend on whether $x \in S$. Hence $E_x(F_{k,t})$ and $\mathrm{Inf}_x(F_{k,t})$ are the erasure entropy and the influence of $x$ for the law $c_\mu(S)^2$. Here $\mu_j = P_t$ for $j \leq m$ and $1 - P_t$ for $j > m$, with $P_t = \Pr[\mathrm{Bin}(2t, \frac{1}{2}) \geq t] \to \frac{1}{2}$. The coefficients $c_\mu(S)$ are continuous in $\mu \in (0,1)^k$ and $\Phi$ is continuous, so both quantities converge to their values at $\mu = \frac{1}{2}$, which are $E_x(\tilde{f}_k)$ and $\mathrm{Inf}_x(\tilde{f}_k) > 0$. The last statement follows from Proposition 11. □

Already $t = 1$, where $T_1$ and $T_1'$ are the OR and the AND of two variables, gives a growing ratio at the forced coordinate, on $2k+1$ variables. By the proof above it is the ratio of $\tilde{f}_k$ under the product measure with bias $\frac{3}{4}$ on $y_1, \dots, y_m$ and $\frac{1}{4}$ on $y_{m+1}, \dots, y_k$. There $D$ and the average over $x$ have coefficients that depend only on $|S \cap \{y_1, \dots, y_m\}|$ and $|S \cap \{y_{m+2}, \dots, y_k\}|$, so the ratio is a double sum over these two numbers and can be computed exactly. It is 1.05, 1.88, 2.57, 3.12, 3.59, 4.12, 4.70 and 5.30 for $k = 3, 5, \dots, 17$, and 13.83, 29.31, 45.28 and 53.32 at $k = 41, 81, 121, 141$, an increase of about 0.39 per unit of $k$; for $\tilde{f}_k$ the values at these four $k$ are 18.62, 38.11, 57.81 and 67.70. Under a bias the coefficients of the majority near its threshold are Krawtchouk-type sums that change sign, and the proof of Proposition 11 does not carry over. For $t = 1$ the ratio is $(1+o(1))(k-1)\log_2 \frac{4}{3}$, which is $(1+o(1))\log_2(1/\mathrm{Inf}_x)$ and so asymptotic to its largest possible value [18]; the proof writes these sums as integrals over the unit circle. The same holds for every fixed $t \geq 1$: the ratio is $(1 + o(1))(k-1)\log_2(1/P_t)$ [19]. At $k = 7$, $t = 1$ the smallest ratio over all coordinates is 2.15, and at $k = 17$, $t = 20$ the forced ratio is 9.59. On monotone functions of at most six variables the rule does no worse than $G_{\mathrm{mon}}(n)$ (Section 7).

## 6. The singleton identities do not suffice

For monotone $f$, $\mu(\{i\}) = \mathrm{Inf}_i(f)^2 = \Pr[i \in U]^2$ for every $i$, and hence $\sum_i \Pr[i \in U]^2 \leq 1$. The following law satisfies both identities, is invariant under permutations, and has unbounded erasure ratio. It is not the spectral distribution of a Boolean function, so it shows only that any proof must use more of the structure.

**Proposition 13.** *For $n \geq 100$ let $p = 1/n$, let $\rho$ be the law of a random subset of $[n]$ containing each element independently with probability $p$, conditioned on having at least two elements, let*

*$d = \rho[i \in U]$, $b = 1/4$, and $\delta = (1-\sqrt{1-4bd})/2$. The law $\mu$ that gives mass $b\rho(S)$ to each $S$ with $|S| \geq 2$, mass $\delta^2$ to each singleton and the rest to $\emptyset$ is a probability law with $\mu(\{i\}) = \Pr_\mu[i \in U]^2$, and*

$$\frac{H(\mathbf{1}[i \in U] \mid U \setminus \{i\})}{\Pr_\mu[i \in U]} \;\geq\; \frac{\log n}{288}.$$

*Proof.* Let $q = \Pr[\mathrm{Bin}(n,p) \geq 2] \geq \Pr[\mathrm{Bin}(n,p) = 2] = \frac{n-1}{2n}(1-\frac{1}{n})^{n-2} \geq \frac{1}{12}$, using $(1-1/n)^{n-2} \geq e^{-1} > 1/3$. Then $d \leq p/q \leq 12/n$, $bd \leq 3/n < 1/4$, so $\delta$ is real, $\delta \leq 2bd \leq 6/n$ and $n\delta^2 \leq 36/n \leq 0.36$; the mass of $\emptyset$ is at least $1 - \frac{1}{4} - 0.36 > 0$. By the choice of $\delta$, $\Pr_\mu[i \in U] = \delta^2 + bd = \delta$. In (1) keep only the $T \not\ni i$ with $|T| \geq 2$: both $T$ and $T \cup \{i\}$ lie in the product part, with masses in ratio $(1-p) : p$, so each pair contributes $(\mu(T) + \mu(T \cup \{i\}))h_2(p)$, and the pairs have total mass $(b/q)\Pr[\mathrm{Bin}(n-1,p) \geq 2] \geq \frac{1}{4} \cdot \frac{1}{12}$, the last factor by the same estimate as for $q$. With $\delta \leq 6/n$ and $h_2(1/n) \geq (\log n)/n$ this gives $E_i/\delta \geq n\, h_2(1/n)/288 \geq (\log n)/288$. □

The exact ratio is 4.59, 5.95, 7.34 and 8.73 at $n = 10^2, 10^3, 10^4, 10^5$.

## 7. Monotone functions on few variables

Let $G_{\mathrm{mon}}(n)$ be the maximum of $\min_{i:\mathrm{Inf}_i>0} E_i/\mathrm{Inf}_i$ over non-constant monotone functions on $n$ variables, and similarly for $H/I$ and $\sum_i E_i/I$. Monotone functions on $n$ variables are the pairs $(f_0, f_1)$ of monotone functions on $n-1$ variables with $f_0 \leq f_1$; there are 7,828,354 of them for $n = 6$ and 2,414,682,040,998 for $n = 7$, the Dedekind numbers. For $n \leq 6$ the program `census_mono.py` evaluates every labelled function. The program `mono_census.c` lets the first function of each pair range over one representative of each orbit of the symmetric group on the first $n-1$ variables, weighted by the orbit size, and checks that the weighted count is the Dedekind number; at $n = 6$ its three maxima and its worst cases for the rules of largest and smallest influence agree with those of `census_mono.py` to $10^{-12}$, although `mono_census.c` breaks ties in favour of a rule and `census_mono.py` against it. It gives the row $n = 7$. Table 1 gives the results.

| $n$ | monotone functions | $G_{\mathrm{mon}}(n)$ | $\max H/I$ | $\max \sum_i E_i/I$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 2 | 6 | 2 | 2 | 2 |
| 3 | 20 | 2.672488983973 | 2.955889582252 | 2.672488983973 |
| 4 | 168 | 2.672488983973 | 3.402475551199 | 2.704153205629 |
| 5 | 7,581 | 2.695887520153 | 3.623740399702 | 2.883566415773 |
| 6 | 7,828,354 | 2.944495303872 | 3.739764017898 | 3.030964070213 |
| 7 | 2,414,682,040,998 | 2.954683814183 | 3.804357069772 | 3.164564560463 |

Table 1. Maxima over all monotone functions on $n$ variables.

For $n = 6$ the maximum of $\min_i E_i/\mathrm{Inf}_i$ is attained by $\mathrm{MAJ}_3$ of three $\mathrm{AND}_2$ on disjoint pairs and by its dual, with every influence 3/16; the maximum of $H/I$ for $n \leq 7$ by $\mathrm{AND}_n$ and $\mathrm{OR}_n$. For $n = 7$ the maximiser of $\min_i E_i/\mathrm{Inf}_i$ has influences 0.09375 at three variables and 0.15625 at four, with ratios 3.0316 and 2.9547; its smallest ratio is at a coordinate of largest influence. For $n \geq 8$ we have only lower bounds. The read-once function $(x_1x_2 \vee x_3x_4) \wedge (x_5x_6 \vee x_7x_8)$ has every influence 21/128 and $E_i/\mathrm{Inf}_i = 3.304701322451$ at every variable, so $G_{\mathrm{mon}}(8) \geq 3.3047$, while $G_{\mathrm{mon}}(7) = 2.9547$; the tribes function [2] $\bigwedge_{j=1}^{5}(x_{2j-1} \vee x_{2j})$, with every influence 81/512, has ratio 3.389192093442 at every variable. The read-once function

$$(x_1 \vee x_2)(x_3 \vee x_4) \vee (x_5 \vee x_6)(x_7 \vee x_8) \vee x_9x_{10}$$

does better: its influences are 49/512 at $x_1, \ldots, x_8$ and 63/512 at $x_9, x_{10}$, with ratios 3.401069972510 and 3.589953807822, so $G_{\mathrm{mon}}(10) \geq 3.4010$. Both functions are read-once, a

class for which the conjecture holds [13, 3]. Up to a permutation of the variables and duality, which leaves every ratio unchanged, a read-once monotone function is a series-reduced planted tree with an OR gate at the root, and there are 261, 2,312 and 68,954 such trees with 8, 10 and 13 leaves [12]. Evaluating all of them for $n \le 13$ shows that the two functions above are the best read-once functions for $n = 8$ and $n = 10$. For $n = 12$ the best is $x_1x_2 \vee x_3x_4 \vee \cdots \vee x_{11}x_{12}$, the dual of the tribes function with six blocks, with every influence 243/2048 and ratio 3.541677755510 at every variable. Since a function of $n$ variables is also a function of $n + 1$ variables, $G_{\mathrm{mon}}$ is nondecreasing, and $G_{\mathrm{mon}}(n) \ge 3.5416$ for $n \ge 12$; for $n = 9$, 11 and 13 the best read-once values, 3.1282, 3.3618 and 3.4242, lie below the bound for $n - 1$. Along the family $\bigvee_{j=1}^{k} x_{2j-1}x_{2j}$, with every influence $\frac{1}{2}(3/4)^{k-1}$, the ratio is 2.3160, 3.0428, 3.3892, 3.5417, 3.5984, 3.6068, 3.5916 and 3.5657 for $k = 3, \ldots, 10$; it is largest at $k = 8$, where it equals 3.606847002096, so $G_{\mathrm{mon}}(n) \ge 3.6068$ for $n \ge 16$. Among ORs of disjoint blocks of the forms $x_1x_2$, $x_1x_2x_3$, $(x_1 \vee x_2)(x_3 \vee x_4)$ and $(x_1 \vee x_2)(x_3 \vee x_4)(x_5 \vee x_6)$ with at most 20 variables, the best is

$$\bigvee_{b=0}^{2} \bigwedge_{j=1}^{3} (x_{6b+2j-1} \vee x_{6b+2j}),$$

with every influence 12321/131072 and ratio 3.713716018539 at every variable, so $G_{\mathrm{mon}}(n) \ge 3.7137$ for $n \ge 18$. With two blocks of two pairs the same construction is the dual of the eight-variable function above.

Larger ORs of blocks need no truth table. Let $f = \bigvee_b g_b$ with the $g_b$ on disjoint sets of variables, and let $a_b$ be the indicator that $g_b$ is false. Then $f = -1 + 2\prod_b a_b$, so $\hat{f}(T) = 2\prod_b \hat{a}_b(T_b)$ for $T \ne \emptyset$, where $T_b$ is the part of $T$ in block $b$. Since $\Phi$ is homogeneous of degree one and $\sum_S \hat{a}_b(S)^2 = \Pr[a_b = 1]$, for a variable $i$ of block 1, with $A = \hat{a}_1^2$, $q = \prod_{b>1} \Pr[a_b = 1]$ and $r = \prod_{b>1} \hat{a}_b(\emptyset)^2$,

$$\begin{aligned}
\mathrm{Inf}_i &= 4q \sum_S A(S \cup \{i\}), \\
E_i &= 4q \sum_{S \not\ni i} \Phi\big(A(S), A(S \cup \{i\})\big) - 4r\,\Phi\big(A(\emptyset), A(\{i\})\big) + \Phi\big(\hat{f}(\emptyset)^2, 4rA(\{i\})\big).
\end{aligned}$$

For $m$ copies of $\bigwedge_{t=1}^{j}(x_{2t-1} \vee x_{2t})$ every influence is $\frac{1}{2}(3/4)^{j-1}\big(1-(3/4)^j\big)^{m-1}$. The ratio is largest at $m = 4$ for $j = 3$ ($n = 24$, ratio 3.783969373526), at $m = 6$ for $j = 4$ ($n = 48$, 3.924260765374) and at $m = 8$ for $j = 5$ ($n = 80$, 3.949934743097); this last value is the largest for $j \le 8$ and $m \le 40$, and no OR of copies of two of these blocks, at most 30 of each, does better. Hence $G_{\mathrm{mon}}(n) \ge 3.7839$ for $n \ge 24$, $G_{\mathrm{mon}}(n) \ge 3.9242$ for $n \ge 48$ and $G_{\mathrm{mon}}(n) \ge 3.9499$ for $n \ge 80$.

The same computation goes through every level of a read-once tower. If $c$ is the indicator of an AND of indicators $c_1, \ldots, c_k$ on disjoint sets of variables, then $\hat{c}(T) = \prod_b \hat{c}_b(T_b)$ for every $T$, the empty set included, and $1 - c$ has the same coefficients as $c$ except at $\emptyset$. So for a tower whose levels alternate AND and OR gates, with fan-ins $k_1, \ldots, k_d$ from the bottom up, the five numbers $\Pr[c = 1]$, $\hat{c}(\emptyset)^2$, $\hat{c}(\{i\})^2$, $\sum_S \hat{c}(S \cup \{i\})^2$ and $\sum_{\emptyset \ne S \not\ni i} \Phi\big(\hat{c}(S)^2, \hat{c}(S \cup \{i\})^2\big)$ at one level follow from those at the level below, and $E_i/\mathrm{Inf}_i$ follows from the top level as above. Coordinate ascent over fan-ins at most 40, with an OR at the top, gives

| $d$ | ratio | fan-ins | $n$ |
|---|---|---|---|
| 4 | 4.082607350869 | 2, 4, 4, 9 | 288 |
| 5 | 4.147038128862 | 2, 4, 3, 4, 9 | 864 |
| 6 | 4.175806194504 | 2, 4, 3, 3, 3, 6 | 1296 |
| 7 | 4.198870450086 | 2, 3, 2, 2, 2, 4, 9 | 1728 |
| 8 | 4.212002610938 | 2, 3, 2, 2, 2, 4, 6, 9 | 10368 |
| 9 | 4.218175761392 | 2, 3, 2, 2, 2, 2, 2, 5, 10 | 9600 |
| 10 | 4.221995523184 | 2, 3, 2, 2, 2, 2, 2, 5, 7, 10 | 67200 |

so $G_{\mathrm{mon}}(n) \geq 4.0826$ for $n \geq 288$ and $G_{\mathrm{mon}}(n) \geq 4.1989$ for $n \geq 1728$. The gain from one more level roughly halves from $d = 7$ on, which suggests that towers of AND and OR gates alone stay below about 4.23. This concerns the minimum over the leaves, which in these towers is the same at every leaf. A single leaf of a read-once AND/OR formula has ratio below $\pi/\ln 2 = 4.5324$, and the ratio comes arbitrarily close to $\pi/\ln 2$ along one path of a deep formula [17]. A small threshold block in place of the variables at the bottom of a tower lowers the ratio: with $\mathrm{MAJ}_3$, $\mathrm{MAJ}_5$ or "at least two of four" as the block, the best towers of depth 6 that the same search finds reach 2.981, 2.533 and 3.697, against 4.176 with variables. Iterated compositions of larger monotone gates reach 4.506 [17], so the values in the table are far from the supremum over all monotone functions.

Table 2 gives, for $n \leq 6$, the largest $E_i/\mathrm{Inf}_i$ at the coordinate chosen by a rule, with ties broken against the rule. The coordinate of largest influence never does worse than $G_{\mathrm{mon}}(n)$ here, and at $n = 7$ it does not either, with ties broken in its favour. The coordinate of smallest positive influence reaches 6.2425 at $n = 7$ even with ties broken in its favour.

| $n$ | largest $\mathrm{Inf}_i$ | smallest $\mathrm{Inf}_i$ | largest $W_i^{(2)}/\mathrm{Inf}_i$ | smallest $W_i^{(2)}/\mathrm{Inf}_i$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 3 | 2.672488983973 | 2.672488983973 | 2.672488983973 | 2.672488983973 |
| 4 | 2.672488983973 | 3.523111966872 | 3.523111966872 | 3.523111966872 |
| 5 | 2.695887520153 | 4.335249356685 | 4.335249356685 | 4.335249356685 |
| 6 | 2.944495303872 | 5.019930166880 | 4.833940887931 | 5.019930166880 |

TABLE 2. Worst ratio at the coordinate selected by each rule, over all monotone functions on $n$ variables.

The program `rule_minmax.py` computes $A(f)$, $B(f)$ and every ratio for all monotone functions on $n \leq 6$ variables. The largest value over $f$ of $\min_{i \in A \cap B} E_i/\mathrm{Inf}_i$ is 2, 2.672488983973, 2.672488983973, 2.695887520153 and 2.944495303872 for $n = 2, \ldots, 6$, which is $G_{\mathrm{mon}}(n)$ in each case. The rule does not always find the best coordinate: the minimum over all coordinates is not attained in $A \cap B$ for 8 of the 168 functions with $n = 4$, 190 of the 7,581 with $n = 5$ and 335,144 of the 7,828,354 with $n = 6$, and among functions whose smallest ratio is positive the quotient of the two minima reaches 1.108, 1.458 and 2.363. At $n = 6$ there are also 360 functions in which some relevant variable has ratio 0 while every variable of $A \cap B$ has a positive ratio, so that the quotient is infinite; for one of them the six ratios are $0, 0, 0.686, 0.686, 0.451, 0.451$ and $A \cap B$ consists of the last two variables. Taking the worst variable of $A \cap B$ instead gives 3.344977967946 at $n = 5$ and 3.650196658624 at $n = 6$; the worst variable of $A$, of $B$ or of $A \cup B$ gives 4.950362212005 at $n = 6$.

## 8. Numerical checks

The script `check_hidden.py` in the code repository computes exact Walsh–Hadamard transforms of $f_k$ for odd $k \leq 17$, of six substituted functions with blocks of sizes 1, 3 and 5, and of $f'_k$ for even $k \leq 18$, and checks Lemma 4, Proposition 6 against a direct evaluation

of the erasure entropy at every variable, Corollary 7, the bounds of Theorem 1, each rule of Theorem 2, and Proposition 9 including monotonicity; it also evaluates the law of Proposition 13 exactly. The census programs are `census_mono.py` ($n \le 6$) and `mono_census.c` ($n = 7$), and `check_small_trees.py` computes the functions on 8 and 10 variables of Section 7 from their truth tables, `check_table.py` evaluates a function given as a hexadecimal truth table, and `read_once_census.py` evaluates every read-once monotone function for $n \le 13$, and `or_of_and2.py` the family $\bigvee_j x_{2j-1}x_{2j}$ for $k \le 11$, and `or_of_blocks.py` the ORs of blocks with at most 20 variables; `or_of_blocks_formula.py` computes larger ORs of blocks by the formula above, after checking it against truth tables of six functions with up to 18 variables, and `read_once_towers.py` checks the recursion for towers against truth tables of five towers with up to 16 variables; `towers_mp.py` carries it out in 40-digit arithmetic, and `climb.py` does the search; `mixed_towers.py` does the same for towers with a threshold block at the bottom, after checking nine of them against truth tables with up to 18 variables. The script `check_xand.py` compares the formula of Proposition 10 with exact transforms of $x \wedge g$ for 300 random monotone $g$ on at most nine variables (largest difference $1.3 \cdot 10^{-15}$) and evaluates it and the bound on a grid of $p$; `check_gk.py` computes $A$, $B$ and every ratio of $f_k$ and $\tilde{f}_k$ for odd $k \le 13$ and checks monotonicity. The script `forced_rule.py` builds $F_{k,t}$ for $(k,t) = (3,1),(5,1),(7,1),(9,1),(3,2),(5,2),(3,3)$, checks that $A \cap B = \{x\}$ and that the ratio at $x$ equals the one computed from the biased expansion of $\tilde{f}_k$ (to $10^{-9}$), and tabulates the latter for $k \le 17$.

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This work was done by multiple AI agents, Claude (Anthropic) and Codex (OpenAI), connected to Math Brain [23] and working together inside the Brain framework [25], a shared, persistent memory in which the agents record claims, proofs, failed attempts and methods, retrieve one another's results, coordinate who works on what, and audit each other's work. For more on the details behind the Brain and Math Brain, see the Math Brain paper [24], the Math Brain repository [23] and the Brain framework repository [25].

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## Declaration of competing interest

The author holds equity in Heights Labs and in Convex Nexus Capital and has a management role at Convex Nexus Capital. These entities are included in the funding declaration above.

## Declaration of generative AI and AI-assisted technologies

The paper comes out of Math Brain, an ongoing project on the use of AI systems for research mathematics, and its results were developed with the Brain [25] and Math Brain [23]. In November 2026 a Claude Fable agent (Anthropic) and Codex agents running OpenAI's GPT-6.1, connected to the Brain and working on the same problem, studied the conjecture for monotone functions; a Codex agent found the constructions of Sections 3–6 other than Propositions 10, 11 and 12, with their proofs, and computed the census for $n \le 6$, and a Claude agent computed the census for $n = 7$ and found the eight-variable function of Section 7 by a local search, and another Claude agent found the ten-variable function by simulated annealing. Claude Opus

5.5 (Anthropic) found Propositions 10, 11 and 12 and the census of the rule of Section 5 built on shortest minterms and maxterms, rederived each proof, wrote the numerical checks and the census of read-once functions and a second census program for $n \leq 6$, prepared the manuscript and audited it. These checks are not peer review. The author directed the work and is responsible for the content of the paper and for decisions concerning its dissemination.

## Code and data availability

Code and outputs: `https://github.com/yspennstate/fei-hidden-coordinates`.

The paper is part of the Math Brain project, whose public repository is `https://github.com/yspennstate/math-brain-public` [23].

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